Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Topic 5.2 Guided Notes: Positive Psychology

Unit 5: Mental and Physical Health | AP Psychology

Directions: Read through the topic overview page below and fill in each blank as you go. Use the tables and activities to check your understanding, then head to the quiz link at the end to test yourself.

Source page: appsychreviewhub.com/overviews/topic5.2

Word Bank

Posttraumatic Growth	*Humanity*	*Gratitude*
Positive Psychology	*Subjective Well-Being*	*Resilience*
Happiness	*Justice*	*Positive Emotions*
Temperance	*Transcendence*	*Courage*
Wisdom		

1. Subjective Experiences and Well-Being

While many branches of psychology focus on treating mental illness and psychological disorders, _____ takes a different approach. It is the branch of psychology that focuses on the study of strengths, pleasant feelings, and the factors that contribute to a good life and human flourishing. Ultimately, it seeks to identify the factors that lead to coping strength and psychological health.

Understanding how people experience joy and meaning is central to this topic. _____ is a person's self-reported evaluation of how happy and satisfied they are with their life, including the balance of pleasant and unpleasant feelings.

- The general state of well-being characterized by life satisfaction and a sense of fulfillment is known as _____. This state relies heavily on experiencing _____—pleasant emotional states such as joy, thankfulness, interest, and contentment that contribute to life satisfaction.
- One proven way to boost your mood is through _____, a positive emotional response that involves recognizing and appreciating the benefits, kindness, or support received from others. Expressing it, a positive subjective experience, increases subjective well-being. (e.g., Keeping a daily journal where you list three things you are thankful for before bed can significantly improve your overall mood over time.)

Apply It: Which Well-Being Concept?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	Over lunch, a retiree sums up how she feels about her life by saying she is mostly satisfied and has had many more good days than bad ones.	
2	A man describes a deep, lasting sense of fulfillment and contentment with the way his life is going.	

#	Scenario	Concept
3	Throughout the day, a girl feels moments of joy at a good song, interest in a new class, and contentment curled up with a book.	
4	Each week, a boy writes a thank-you note to someone who helped him and takes a moment to appreciate the kindness he received.	

2. Signature Strengths and Virtues

Positive psychologists, like Martin Seligman, emphasize that focusing on what we do best naturally leads to a better life. People who exercise their signature strengths or virtues report higher levels of positive objective experiences such as happiness and subjective well-being.

A classification of character strengths has been developed around 6 categories of virtues:

- _____: Characterized by the ability to think critically, use knowledge effectively, and make sound judgments based on experience and understanding.
- _____: Characterized by persistence, bravery, and the willingness to act despite fear or adversity. (e.g., Speaking up for a classmate who is being treated unfairly, even if you are afraid of the social backlash.)
- _____: Involves caring, valuing close relationships, and showing kindness and compassion toward others.
- _____: Involves fairness, treating others equally, and contributing to the well-being of the community or society.
- _____: Involves self-control, moderation, and the ability to regulate impulses and behaviors.
- _____: Involves appreciating beauty, finding meaning, and feeling a connection to something larger than oneself.

Apply It: Which Virtue?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	A judge weighs the evidence carefully, draws on years of experience, and reaches a sound decision.	
2	A firefighter keeps going back into a smoky building even though he is afraid, because someone is trapped inside.	
3	A nurse learns each patient's name and story and treats every one of them with warmth and compassion.	
4	A referee applies the rules equally to both teams, and a citizen organizes a neighborhood cleanup that benefits everyone.	
5	A student feels the urge to snap at a classmate who annoyed her, but she takes a deep breath and answers calmly.	
6	A hiker pauses at a mountain summit, awed by the sunrise, feeling part of something much larger than herself.	

3. Overcoming Adversity

Positive psychology isn't just about ignoring the bad things in life; it's about how we respond to them. _____ is the ability to adapt, recover, and maintain functioning in the face of stress, adversity, or trauma. Beyond just bouncing back, some people experience profound personal improvement.

- _____: This is the positive psychological change that can occur as a result of struggling with highly challenging or traumatic life experiences. This positive subjective experience may result after the experience of trauma or stress. (e.g., A student who goes through a severe and life-threatening illness may emerge from the hospital with a brand-new appreciation for life and a desire to start a foundation to help others with the same disease.)

Apply It: Resilience or Posttraumatic Growth?

Using the word bank above, identify which concept best matches each scenario.

#	Scenario	Concept
1	After a hurricane damages their home, a family copes, rebuilds, and returns to their normal daily life.	
2	After surviving a car accident, a man feels more appreciative of his loved ones and starts volunteering for road safety, feeling more purposeful than he ever did before.	

4. Don't Trip Up! (Common Misconceptions)

⚠️ Resilience vs. Posttraumatic Growth: Students sometimes use these terms interchangeably on FRQs. _____ means "bouncing back" to your normal baseline after a hardship. _____ means exceeding your previous baseline and becoming stronger, more purposeful, or more appreciative of life because of the trauma.

5. Quick Check: Review Questions

Circle the best answer for each question below.

1. When asked to rate her own overall happiness and life satisfaction on a survey, a woman reflects on the general balance of positive versus negative emotions she has felt lately before giving her answer. This self-reported evaluation of one's own happiness and life satisfaction is called:

A. Resilience
B. Subjective Well-Being
C. Posttraumatic Growth
D. Temperance

2. A man consistently prioritizes spending quality time with his close friends and family, showing genuine compassion, kindness, and care for the important people in his life above almost everything else. According to Seligman's classification of character strengths, this focus on close relationships and kindness best reflects the virtue of:

- **A.** Wisdom
- **B.** Justice
- **C.** Temperance
- **D.** Humanity

3. Even though he is surrounded by delicious desserts at a party, a man practices notable self-control and moderation, choosing to eat just one small portion rather than overindulging. According to Seligman's classification of character strengths, this ability to regulate impulses best reflects the virtue of:

- **A.** Justice
- **B.** Wisdom
- **C.** Courage
- **D.** Temperance

4. After going through a genuinely difficult and stressful divorce, a woman manages to successfully adapt, cope with the challenges, and eventually return to her same normal, stable, and functional baseline level of daily life. This ability to bounce back and maintain functioning after adversity is called:

- **A.** Resilience
- **B.** Subjective Well-Being
- **C.** Posttraumatic Growth
- **D.** Gratitude

5. After surviving a severe, life-threatening illness, a student doesn't just return to how she was before; she emerges from the hospital with a profound new appreciation for life and a powerful new sense of purpose, going on to start a charitable foundation to help others facing the same disease. This positive change, which exceeds a person's previous baseline because of trauma, is called:

- **A.** Eustress
- **B.** Posttraumatic Growth
- **C.** Temperance
- **D.** Resilience

✅ Check Your Progress

Done with your notes? Head over to the Quiz to test what you've learned:
https://appsychreviewhub.com/quiz

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